

“What happened in New York was unbelievable!” According to Stanford psychologist, Philip Zimbardo (1969), “In less than three days what remained was a battered, useless hunk of metal, the result of 23 incidents of destructive contact” (p. 286). Zimbardo made these observations during an experiment in which he left two cars unattended in Palo Alto, CA and in the Bronx borough of New York City. This research was quoted by Wilson & Kelling (1982) in their seminal article, *Broken Windows*, which was referenced in chapter five of Cathy O’Neil’s (2016) book, *Weapons of Math Destruction*, and will be the focus of my deep dive.

“We suggest that ‘untended’ behavior also leads to the breakdown of community controls” (Wilson & Kelling, 1982, p. 31). The untended behavior was a reference Zimbardo’s vehicle experiment. In contrast to the vehicle left in the Bronx, the Palo Alto vehicle remained untouched. After a week, Zimbardo and two of his students took a sledgehammer to the Palo Alto vehicle, smashing it themselves. Random observers joined, taking turns smashing the windshield and windows (hence, “broken windows”), then “they all attacked at once” (p. 290). Wilson and Kelling argue that untended property damage will follow a similar cascading effect.

Broken Windows is a cycle. Failure to police leads to property damage. Untended property damage leads to social decay. Declining conditions lead people to move out of the city. The persistence of nuisance crime (e.g., “the ill smelling drunk, the rowdy teenager, or the importuning beggar”; Wilson & Kelling, 1982, p. 34), induce the remaining citizens to administer the law themselves. This fate can be avoided, they argue, if police enforce unwritten laws protecting the “regulars” from the “strangers” (e.g., the “decent folk” from the unknown; Wilson & Kelling, 1982, p. 30).

I have observed these trends. A sense of lawlessness by George Zimmerman (a “regular”) led to the shooting of (a “stranger”) Trayvonnie Martin (Park et al., 2012). Similarly, it led Kyle Rittenhouse to Kenosha, Wisconsin, where he shot and killed two people (Vogt et al., 2021). He was responding to riots (by “strangers”) that occurred alongside Black Lives Matter protests. The riots, not to be confused with the protests, claimed the lives of an estimated 25 people (Beckett, 2020), resulted in an estimated two-billion dollars of property damage (Polumbo, 2020). Consequently, backlash against police from protestors contributed to reduced policing during the Capitol Insurrection. Former DC Police Chief, Steven Sund, claimed his request for police presence was denied due to “optics,” and that Mayor Muriel Bowser “also wanted light police presence ... to avoid a similar scenario as last summer, when federal forces responded to demonstrators opposed to police abuse” (Diaz, 2021).

Broken Windows Theory is not without merit. The 2020 riots were, effectively, a broken window. The Capitol Insurrection may have been the result of an untended broken window. When police retreat and “regulars” take the law into their hands, things go wrong. My takeaway from Broken Windows Theory and these anecdotes is that policing is necessary. However, we cannot ignore the suffering of the “strangers” who are subject to the tyranny of Broken Windows Theory.

References

- Beckett, L. (2020, October 31). At least 25 Americans were killed during protests and political unrest in 2020. *The Guardian*.
<https://www.theguardian.com/world/2020/oct/31/americans-killed-protests-political-unrest-acled>
- Diaz, J. (2021, January 11). Ex-Capitol Police Chief Says Requests For National Guard Denied 6 Times In Riots. *NPR*. <https://www.npr.org/2021/01/11/955548910/ex-capitol-police-chief-rebuffs-claims-national-guard-was-never-called-during-ri>
- O'Neil, C. (2016). *Weapons of math destruction: How big data increases inequality and threatens democracy* (First). Crown Publishing Group.
- Park, H., McLean, A., Roberts, G., & Tse, A. (2012, June 21). *Events Leading to the Shooting of Trayvon Martin* [Archive]. The New York Times.
<https://archive.nytimes.com/www.nytimes.com/interactive/2012/04/02/us/the-events-leading-to-the-shooting-of-trayvon-martin.html>
- Polumbo, B. (2020, September 16). *George Floyd riots caused record-setting \$2 billion in damage, new report says. Here's why the true cost is even higher*.
<https://fee.org/articles/george-floyd-riots-caused-record-setting-2-billion-in-damage-new-report-says-here-s-why-the-true-cost-is-even-higher/>
- Vogt, A., Sangal, A., Wagner, M., Macaya, M., & Mahtani, M. (2021, November 19). *Kyle Rittenhouse not guilty on all charges: Live updates*. CNN. <https://www.cnn.com/us/live-news/kyle-rittenhouse-trial-verdict-watch-11-19-21>
- Wilson, J. Q., & Kelling, G. L. (1982, March). The police and neighborhood safety: Broken windows. *The Atlantic*, 249(3), 29–36, 38.
- Zimbardo, P. G. (1969). The human choice: Individuation, reason, and order versus deindividuation, impulse, and chaos. *Nebraska Symposium on Motivation*, 17, 237–307.